

FREE DOWNLOAD

The Senior Posing Guide.

*Posing is a skill.
Here is how to learn it.*

The fundamentals that change everything.

Standing, sitting & movement poses.

What to do with your hands — always.

Expressions, eyes & authentic moments.

How to warm up before your session.

What to expect — your session, your way.

27

WELCOME

Posing Is a Skill.

Not a talent
you either
have or don't.

*"The stiffness you feel in photos? Completely
normal. Not a you problem. A practice problem."*

Every senior who walks into a session feeling stiff walks out with images they love. The stiffness doesn't last — it never does. This guide exists to shorten the warm-up and get you to the good part faster.

Posing is our job, not yours. We direct everything — where to stand, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left guessing or told to just 'smile and look natural.'

But understanding a few fundamentals before you arrive means you warm up faster, feel more confident, and know your angles before we ever get started. Read this once. Practice in a mirror. Then show up ready.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01** The Fundamentals →
- 02** Standing Poses →
- 03** Sitting Poses →
- 04** Movement & Walking →
- 05** What to Do With Your Hands →
- 06** Expressions & Eyes →
- 07** Your Session — What to Expect →

NP SENIORS — ALL-INCLUSIVE

You show up. We take care of everything else.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

THE FUNDAMENTALS

The Fundamentals.

These are the principles that apply to every single pose — standing, sitting, walking, leaning. Master these and everything else becomes easy. Practice each one in front of a mirror before your session.

+ The chin trick. Practice this first.

Push your chin slightly forward and down — not up, not back. This one move defines your jawline, eliminates double-chin shadows, and makes your neck look longer. It feels unnatural. It photographs beautifully. Practice until it feels automatic.

+ Turn your body — find your angle.

Facing straight-on is almost never your best angle. Turn your shoulders 30–45 degrees away from the camera while keeping your face toward it. This creates dimension and makes your waist appear smaller. We'll find your stronger side in the first five minutes.

+ Relax your shoulders — actively.

Tension goes straight to your shoulders first. Before every shot, take a breath and consciously drop your shoulders down and back. This one physical reset changes your expression, your posture, and the energy of the image.

+ Poses are starting points, not destinations.

The best images almost always happen between the planned poses — when you're adjusting, laughing, looking away and back. Don't try to hold a pose perfectly. Move within it. The camera catches the in-between.

+ Shift your weight — never stand equal.

Distribute your weight evenly on both feet and you'll look rigid. Shift 70% of your weight to one leg, let the other hip drop naturally. Suddenly you have shape, angle, and personality. This is the single most impactful thing you can do in any standing pose.

+ Lean slightly forward — in the right poses.

In seated and casual poses, a subtle forward lean from the waist creates confident posture and stronger presence. It feels strange. It looks incredible. We'll tell you exactly when to use it.

+ Breathe. Right before the shutter.

Take a breath and let half of it out just before we shoot. Your shoulders drop, your expression softens, and you go from 'trying to pose' to actually being present. We'll cue this — but knowing it exists helps.

+ Trust the first ten minutes.

Every single senior feels stiff at the start. Every single one relaxes by the time we're into the session. We know this rhythm. We build sessions around it. Your only job is to trust the process and stay present.

PRACTICE BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

Stand in front of a mirror and practice: chin forward and down · weight shift · shoulder turn · shoulder drop.

02 Standing Poses.

Standing poses show your full outfit and silhouette — they're often the most polished images of the session. The key is weight shift, angle, and giving your hands a job. Never stand flat-footed with equal weight.

POSE 1

Weight Shift & Turn

Shift weight to back leg, cross front ankle in front. Turn shoulders 45° from camera, face toward it. Hands: one thumb in pocket, other hand relaxed. Classic and endlessly flattering.

1

POSE 2

The Lean

One shoulder against a wall, tree, or post. Hip pops out slightly. Arms: one across body holding opposite elbow, or both hands in pockets. Creates a relaxed, editorial look that works anywhere.

2

POSE 3

Cross-Ankle Stand

Cross one ankle in front of the other while standing. Adds elegance and visual interest to the lower body without effort. Works beautifully in dresses and wide-leg trousers.

3

POSE 4

The Profile Turn

Turn your body almost fully sideways to the camera, chin turned back slightly toward the lens. Shows the silhouette of your outfit and elongates the neck. Especially beautiful with flowy dresses.

4

POSE 5

Step Forward

One foot takes a small step toward the camera. Weight shifts forward. Creates movement even in a still pose. Shoulders stay back, chin forward and down. More dynamic than a flat stand.

5

POSE 6

Against Architecture

Back against a wall, arms relaxed at sides or one hand touching the surface lightly. Turn face toward the light. Urban sessions: use doorways, columns, textured walls. Natural: use tree trunks, fences.

6

STANDING TIPS THAT MAKE EVERY POSE WORK BETTER

+ Feet: never parallel, never equal.

One foot always slightly in front of or behind the other. Weight always shifted. Equal-weight parallel feet is the fastest way to look stiff on camera.

+ The hand on the hip rule.

Hand on hip is a classic pose — but only if the elbow points back toward the camera, not forward. Forward elbow reads as aggressive. Back elbow reads as confident and feminine.

+ Shoulders back and down — always.

Rolled shoulders read as insecure on camera. Drop them down and back before every shot. This one adjustment changes your whole posture and the energy of the image.

+ Look for something to interact with.

A fence, a wall, a doorway, a tree. Poses that give you something to lean against, touch, or frame yourself within always look more natural than floating in open space.

03 Sitting Poses.

Sitting poses are often where the most natural and genuine images happen. They're lower-energy, easier to relax into, and give you more options for hand placement. We almost always start here to warm up.

POSE 7

Ground Sit — Knees to Side

Sit on the ground with both knees bent to one side. Lean slightly forward. One hand on the ground beside you, other hand in lap or touching hair. Relaxed, editorial, works beautifully outdoors.

7

POSE 8

Steps & Ledges

Sit on a step, a ledge, or a low wall. Lean elbows on knees for a casual feel, or sit tall with hands folded for a more polished look. Cross your ankles for added elegance.

8

POSE 9

Legs Extended

Sit with legs extended forward and slightly to one side. Prop yourself on one hand behind you. Weight shifts create a long, relaxed silhouette. Best on grass or a clean outdoor surface.

9

POSE 10

Cross-Legged

Sit cross-legged on the ground or a low surface. Both hands in lap or one resting on the knee. Chin forward and down. Casual and grounded — great for personality-driven shots.

10

POSE 11

Side Lean

Sit sideways on a surface and lean to one side. One arm extended along the surface behind you, other hand resting naturally. Creates a long diagonal line through the frame.

11

POSE 12

Knees Up, Looking Away

Sit on the ground with knees pulled up, arms resting lightly on them, looking off into the distance or back over one shoulder. Contemplative, genuine, and one of the most timeless poses.

12

SITTING TIPS

+ Lean forward slightly from the waist.

Sitting back makes you look slouched. Leaning slightly forward creates engaged, confident posture and slims the silhouette. It feels like you're about to stand up. It looks incredible.

+ Be aware of what the skirt or dress is doing.

Smooth it out, tuck it under, or let it spread naturally — but be intentional. Bunched fabric in the lap creates visual noise. We'll help you manage this during the session.

+ Cross your ankles — always.

Crossed ankles add elegance and visual interest to any sitting pose. They work whether you're sitting on steps, a wall, or the ground. Make it a habit for every sitting shot.

+ The ground is your friend.

Some of the best senior portrait images happen on the ground. Don't worry about grass stains or getting dirty — that's what editing is for. Let yourself settle in fully.

MOVEMENT & WALKING

Movement & Walking.

Movement beats stillness every time. The best images from almost every session happen when the senior is in motion — walking, turning, laughing, looking back. Movement relaxes the body and creates genuine expression.

MOVEMENT POSES

+ Walk toward the camera.

Start 20 feet back and walk naturally toward us. Eyes can look at the camera, down at the ground, or off to the side — we'll vary it. This single prompt creates more usable images than almost anything else.

+ Walk away and look back over your shoulder.

Walk away from the camera, then turn to look back over one shoulder. The twist of the turn creates a beautiful diagonal through the frame. Works especially well with flowy dresses and long hair.

+ The twirl.

Step out, spin, let the dress or skirt fly. You don't need to be graceful — the camera captures the motion, not the technique. Even jeans and a jacket look beautiful mid-twirl. Just commit to it.

+ Hair movement.

Toss your hair, brush it back from your face, or let the wind catch it. We'll time the shot to the movement. Have a light-hold product in your touch-up kit to manage it between takes.

TRANSITION POSES

+ Adjusting your outfit.

Smoothing your skirt, tucking a strand of hair, pulling your jacket. These small self-adjusting moments photograph as natural, candid, and completely real. Some of our best images come from 'non-poses' like these.

+ Looking down, then up.

Stand or sit with eyes down. On our cue, slowly lift your eyes to the camera. The moment of connection as your gaze comes up is often where the most genuine expression lives.

+ Laughing at nothing.

We'll say something, make a joke, or ask you to think of something funny. Real laughter is always better than a posed smile. The session should feel fun — and these moments reflect that.

+ Shifting between poses.

The few seconds between one pose and the next — when you're moving your weight, shaking out your hands, resetting — we're still shooting. Some of the most natural images come from exactly these in-between moments.

THE TRUTH ABOUT MOVEMENT

Don't perform the movement. Just do it.

Walking like you're walking and laughing because something is funny always looks better than walking 'for the camera.' Be in the moment. We catch it.

05

What to Do With Your Hands.

Hands are where most people freeze. They're in the frame more than you'd expect — especially in close-up and three-quarter shots. The solution is always the same: give them a job.

Thumb in pocket.

One or both thumbs hooked in a pocket or waistband. Fingers rest naturally outside. Instantly relaxed and natural-looking. Works for any outfit with any kind of pocket.

Touch your hair lightly.

Run fingers through your hair, tuck a strand behind your ear, or hold a section lightly. Not adjusting — just touching. Creates movement and draws attention to your face.

Hold something meaningful.

Your varsity jacket, a small bouquet, your instrument. Props give your hands a clear purpose and add a layer of personality to the image.

Lightly on the collarbone.

One hand resting lightly at the collarbone or touching jewelry. Graceful and feminine. Draws the eye upward toward your face. Works especially well in close-up shots.

Arm across the body.

One arm crosses lightly across the waist, hand resting on the opposite forearm or elbow. Creates shape and fills the space between your body and arm without looking forced.

Both hands in hair.

Both hands in your hair, lifting it or running fingers through it. A moment of movement. Works beautifully with wind or a flowy dress nearby. Commit fully for best results.

Holding your jacket or cardigan.

Pull open a jacket or cardigan with one hand, or tuck it back with both. Gives your hands a clear task and adds texture and motion to the outfit.

Relaxed at your side — with intention.

If hands are at your sides, keep fingers slightly curved — not stiff, not fully open. A loose, natural curl is almost invisible on camera. Flat or rigid fingers photograph as tense.

THE ONE RULE

Never let your hands just hang. Always give them a reason to be exactly where they are.

EXPRESSIONS & EYES

Expressions & Eyes.

Expression is the difference between a portrait and a photograph. Your eyes communicate more than any pose ever could. Here's how to think about expression — and how to get there naturally.

EXPRESSION TYPES

+ The genuine smile — not the camera smile.

Think of something actually funny. Or listen to music that makes you happy. We'll make it happen during the session. The goal is never 'smile for the camera' — it's creating a moment worth smiling at.

+ The soft smile — serious but warm.

Slightly upturned lips, relaxed jaw, eyes slightly squinted. Not a full smile, not neutral. Communicates confidence and calm. This is often the expression in the framed print above the fireplace.

+ Neutral and strong.

No smile. Eyes forward or slightly away. Chin forward and down. This reads as editorial and confident on camera. Many seniors find it awkward because they feel like they look mean. They never do.

+ The real laugh.

We'll earn this. When it happens — and it always does — it produces the most authentic images of the entire session. Your only job is to not suppress it when it comes.

WHERE TO LOOK

+ Directly at the camera.

The most powerful connection. Eyes that look directly into the lens look directly at whoever views the image — for the rest of their life. We use this for the images that will get framed.

+ Just past the camera.

Looking slightly past the lens — at something just over our shoulder. Creates a thoughtful, slightly contemplative quality without losing the sense of presence. Great for variety within a look.

+ Down, then up on cue.

Eyes down, then slowly lifted to the camera on our cue. The moment your gaze comes up is almost always where the most genuine expression lives. We use this often.

+ Off to the side — natural and candid.

Looking completely off to one side or into the distance. Gives an image a candid, lifestyle quality. Works beautifully in motion shots and creates variety within a single pose.

THE SQUINCH — THE ONE EXPRESSION TRICK WORTH KNOWING

Squint very slightly — just the lower eyelid lifting a touch. Not a full squint, not wide open. This slight narrowing reads as confidence and warmth on camera. Wide-open eyes in every shot read as surprised. A slight squinch reads as engaged. Practice in a mirror — it's subtle but makes a real difference in close-up portraits.

07

Your Session, Your Way.

This is how a Nydam Photography senior session actually flows — so nothing is a surprise when you get there. Knowing the rhythm in advance means you can relax into it instead of wondering what comes next.

THE FIRST 10–15 MINUTES

This is the warmup — and it is intentional. We ease into things with movement: walking, adjusting, getting comfortable with the space. No formal poses yet. No pressure to perform. The camera is running. We're capturing. But the real direction hasn't started. By the time it does, you've already forgotten to be stiff.

THE GUIDED EXPERIENCE

Every pose, every angle, every expression is guided with intention. You'll always know where to stand, where to look, and where to put your hands — because we'll be right there with you. If something feels off, just say so. We'd rather find what works for you than have you hold anything that doesn't feel right.

OUTFIT CHANGES

Outfit changes are built into the session timeline. We'll plan the flow around them and find a private, comfortable spot for you to change. Bring your touch-up kit. Reapply your lips between looks. Take a breath and reset — each new outfit is a fresh start.

THE SECOND HALF

This is where the best images almost always happen. You're warmed up, relaxed, and no longer thinking about what your face is doing. The session stops feeling like a session and starts feeling like a great afternoon. We're still working — but it doesn't feel like it anymore.

"We come prepared — every session planned with intention. And then we create something real — something that reflects exactly who you are in this season of life. Something that stops you in your tracks ten years from now."

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceñeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

nydamphoto.com · arlen.nydam@gmail.com